

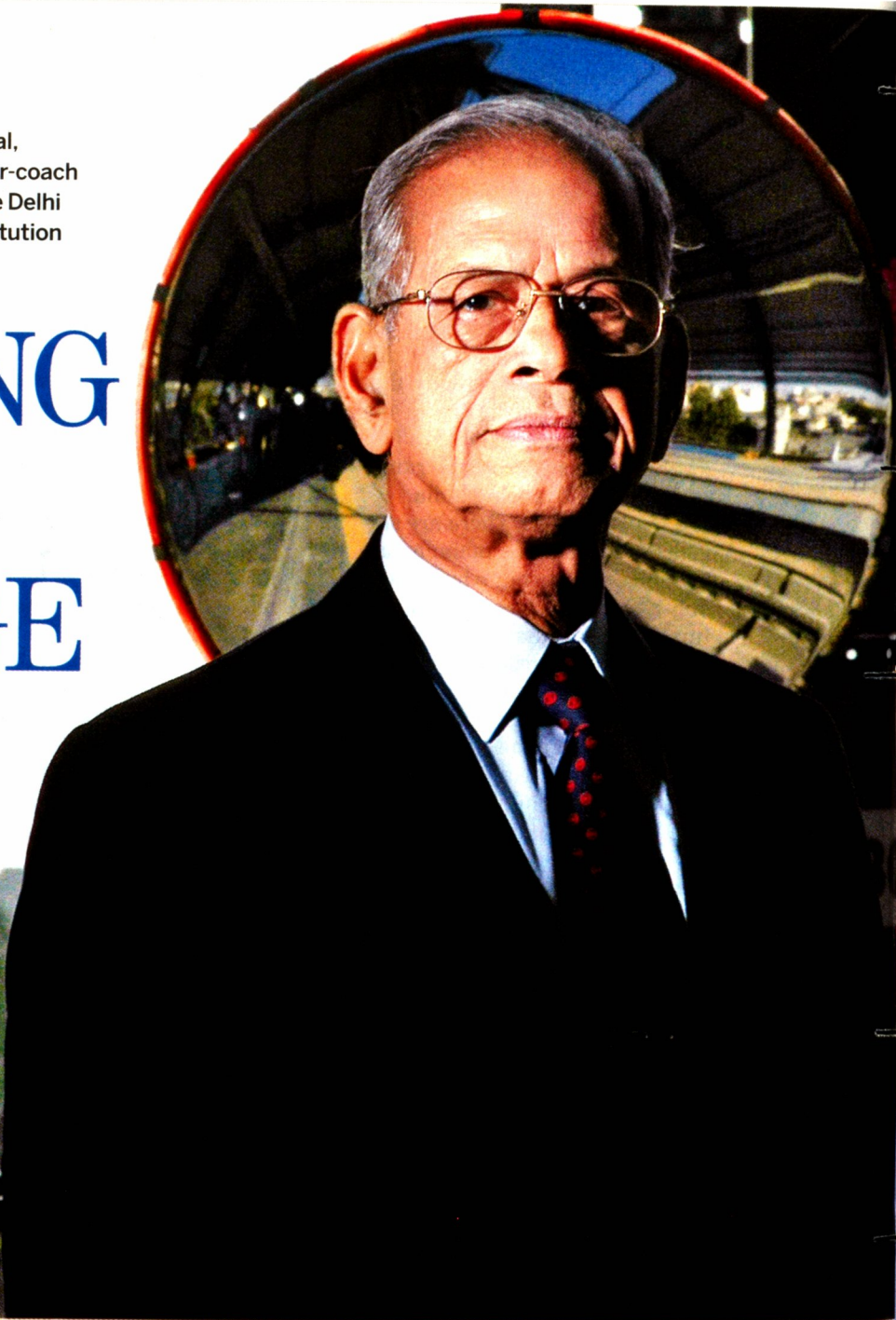
NATION
BUILDERS

SPIRIT OF INDIA SPECIAL

DMRC Established 1997

Stretching across 76.4 km of the capital, carrying 8,37,000 commuters in 71 four-coach trains running 1,328 trips everyday, the Delhi Metro is a study in how to build an institution with brick, mortar and an iron will

LEADING THE CHANGE



Elattuvapil Sreedharan is on the move. Literally. The 77-year-old Lee Kuan Yew-esque managing director of the Delhi Metro Railway Corporation (DMRC) is negotiating traffic and an enervating Delhi rain in his Toyota Previa. On his way to catch a flight to Bangalore, as Sreedharan's vehicle negotiates the log-jammed evening rush hour traffic, he

frets about Delhi's shocking lack of drainage despite 22 per cent of surface area being roads. He elaborates on the two cultural impediments bedeviling government projects in India: postponing decisions and diffusing responsibility. When Sreedharan, a career railway technocrat took over the DMRC in 1997 after successfully completing the Konkan Railway, he insisted that he be

handed all power to lay down a work ethic and have complete financial powers. "A chief executive must be fully trusted. There is no halfway trust. If he doesn't perform, throw him out." He cites Israel's military campaigns won against great odds only through decisive leadership, a metaphor for the battles he had to wage to allow the DMRC greater autonomy. Today, the Delhi Metro is a